sometimes summoning him for purposes outside the call of army duty, when Kaul was only a lieutenant colonel. In 1953, Nehru entrusted Kaul with the delicate task of overseeing the arrest of Sheikh Abdullah and acting as a political troubleshooter in Kashmir.

Unlike Thimayya and most of the other generals who were army and corps commanders at the time, Kaul had virtually no combat experience. Almost everyone who interacted with Kaul during this period comments on his hypersensitivity about his lack of regimental and active service. After being commissioned into an infantry battalion, Kaul had voluntarily shifted to the Army Supply Corps while he was still a junior officer. Kaul used the term ‘national priority’ to explain the reason for this shift—a somewhat dubious explanation as no junior officer was likely to be accorded that sort of importance. As a result, Bijji Kaul had not even commanded an infantry company, let alone a battalion, either in war or peace. Though commissioned into the army well before the outbreak of World War II, Bijji Kaul was assigned sundry jobs, none of which had anything to do with combat.

After Independence, his rise had been spectacular and completely at odds with the existing ethos of the armed forces where each appointment in an officer’s career is a vital cog in his own training that enables him to take on responsibility at the next level. Back in 1947, Kaul was plucked from obscurity to serve as India’s military attaché in Washington DC while also being a member of the quasi-political Armed Forces Nationalisation Committee. In 1948, he was again selected to be the military adviser to the Indian delegation to the Security Council on the Kashmir issue, which was where he first met Krishna Menon.

Nehru then entrusted Kaul with the command of the Jammu and Kashmir Militia, but he had to be withdrawn from this post owing to his differences with Sheikh Abdullah, the then prime minister of Kashmir. By the early 1950s, it was fairly obvious to the rank and file that Kaul was Nehru’s trusted man.

After Independence, Kaul repeatedly served under Thorat. The first tenure was in Army HQ when Thorat was posted as the Deputy Director in the Adjutant General’s Branch and Kaul was one of his staff officers. ‘His posting to Delhi coincided with the feverish political activity connected with the trial of I.N.A. officers in which Congress leaders, including Pandit Nehru and Sardar Patel, were taking active part. It gave Kaul an excellent